GENERATIVE AI & AGENTIC AI · LESSON 7 OF 12

AI Agents and Agentic AI: Loops, Planning, Memory, Multi-Agent Systems and When to Use Them

Understand what makes software "agentic". Workflows vs agents, the agent loop (observe, think, act), ReAct-style reasoning with tools, planning and task decomposition, short- and long-term memory, guardrails and stopping conditions, multi-agent patterns (orchestrator–workers, evaluator–optimiser, routing), the 2026 agent platforms, and how to decide whether a problem needs an agent at all, with a runnable data-analysis agent.

● DVA + AI class 1 (AI vs GenAI vs Agentic AI) · GenAI Launchpad

✦ 2026 agent platforms: Claude Agent SDK, Managed Agents, LangGraph, OpenAI Agents SDK, CrewAI

Intermediate ⏱ 120 min

By the end of this lesson you can

- Distinguish single LLM calls, workflows and autonomous agents
- Implement an agent loop with tools, an observation history and stopping conditions
- Apply planning, reflection and memory patterns
- Describe multi-agent patterns and agent frameworks
- Decide when an agent is worth its cost and risk, and design guardrails

Datasets used

`superstore_sales.csv`

AI, GenAI and agentic AI

	Traditional AI / ML	Generative AI	Agentic AI
Does	Predicts or classifies	Creates content (text, code, images)	Pursues a goal through multi-step actions
Example	Churn score	Draft a retention email	Find at-risk customers, draft personalised offers, schedule them, report results
Control	Fixed pipeline	One request → one response	Model decides the next step in a loop, using tools

Workflows vs agents

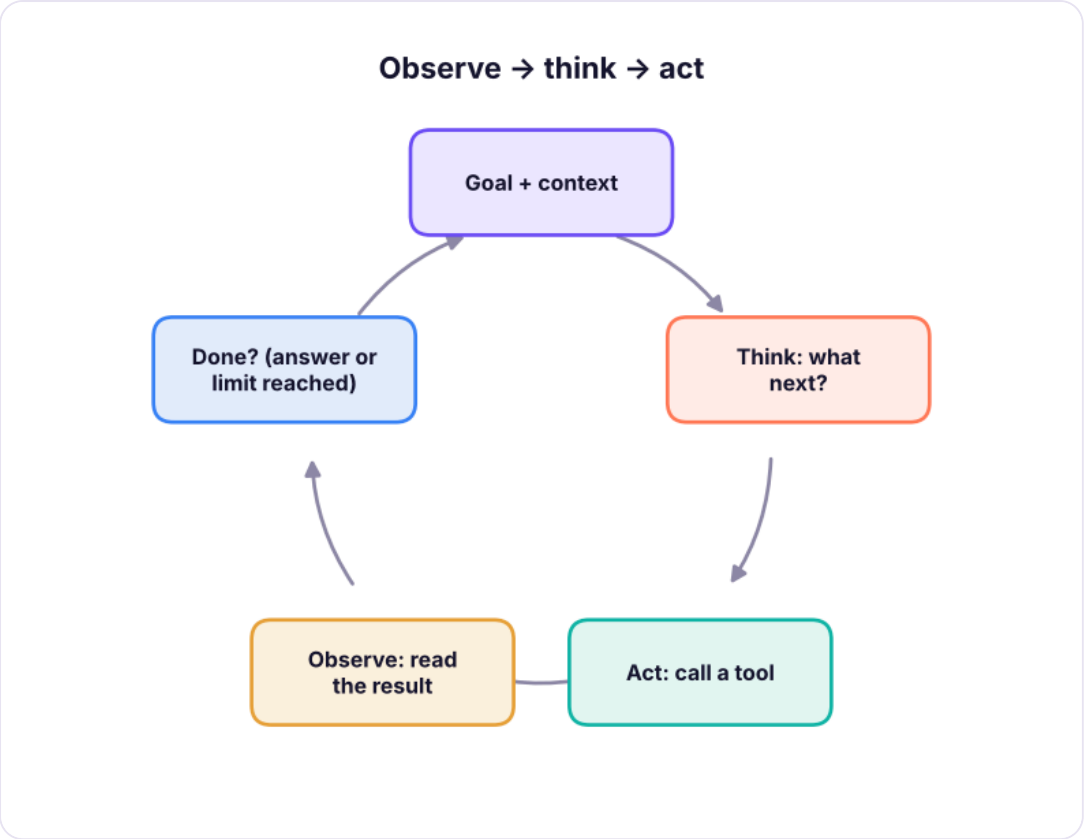


Increasing autonomy: start with the simplest option that works.

- **Workflow:** your code decides the path ("extract → classify → if complaint, draft reply"). Predictable, cheap, easy to test.
- **Agent:** the model decides the path at run time: which tool, which order, when to stop. Flexible for open-ended tasks, but costlier, slower and harder to test.

Anthropic's guidance ("Building effective agents"): use the simplest pattern that works; reach for agents when the task is **open-ended, multi-step, valuable enough to justify cost and latency, and errors can be caught** (tests, reviews, rollback).

The agent loop



Every agent is a loop around a model with tools and memory.

A runnable data-analysis agent

The agent below answers business questions about the sales data. A real LLM would choose each action; here a transparent rule-based "brain" plays that role so the loop runs offline, but the structure (tools, scratchpad, step limit, final answer) is the same as in production frameworks.

Python

```
import json, re, duckdb, pandas as pd, numpy as np
sales = pd.read_csv("superstore_sales.csv", parse_dates=["order_date"]); con =
duckdb.connect(); con.register("sales", sales)
def sql(q): return con.execute(q).df().round(2)
TOOLS = {
    "profit_by": lambda dim, year=2025: sql(f"SELECT {dim}, ROUND(SUM(profit)/1e6, 2) AS
profit_m, ROUND(100*SUM(profit)/SUM(sales), 1) AS margin FROM sales WHERE YEAR(order_date)
= {int(year)} GROUP BY 1 ORDER BY profit_m"),
    "discount_effect": lambda sub_category: sql(f"SELECT CASE WHEN discount = 0 THEN '0%'
WHEN discount ⩽ 0.2 THEN '1-20%' ELSE '>20%' END AS band, COUNT(*) AS n,
ROUND(100*SUM(profit)/SUM(sales), 1) AS margin FROM sales WHERE sub_category =
'{sub_category}' GROUP BY 1 ORDER BY 1"),
    "trend": lambda sub_category: sql(f"SELECT YEAR(order_date) AS yr,
ROUND(SUM(profit)/1e6, 2) AS profit_m FROM sales WHERE sub_category = '{sub_category}'
GROUP BY 1 ORDER BY 1"),
}
class Brain:
    """Stand-in for the LLM policy: looks at the goal and the observations so far and picks
the next action."""
    def next_action(self, goal, scratch):
        done = [s["action"] for s in scratch]
        if "profit_by" not in done: return {"thought": "First find where we lose money.",
"action": "profit_by", "args": {"dim": "sub_category"}}
        worst = scratch[0]["observation"].iloc[0]["sub_category"]
        if "trend" not in done: return {"thought": f"{worst} is the biggest loss-maker. Is
it getting worse?", "action": "trend", "args": {"sub_category": worst}}
        if "discount_effect" not in done: return {"thought": f"Check whether discounts
explain the {worst} losses.", "action": "discount_effect", "args": {"sub_category": worst}}
        d = scratch[2]["observation"].set_index("band")["margin"]
        return {"thought": "I have enough evidence.", "final": f"{worst} lost ₹
{abs(scratch[0]['observation'].iloc[0]['profit_m'])}M in 2025. Margin is {d.get('0%')}%
without discount "
                f"but {d.get('>20%')}% when discounts exceed 20%. Recommendation: cap
{worst} discounts at 20% and review pricing."}
def run_agent(goal, brain, max_steps=6):
    scratch = []
    for step in range(1, max_steps + 1):
        decision = brain.next_action(goal, scratch)
        print(f"step {step} THINK: {decision['thought']}")
        if "final" in decision: return decision["final"]
        obs = TOOLS[decision["action"]](**decision["args"])
        print(f"        ACT: {decision['action']}({decision['args']}) → {len(obs)} rows;
first: {obs.iloc[0].to_dict()}")
        scratch.append({"action": decision["action"], "args": decision["args"],
"observation": obs})
    return "Stopped: step limit reached without an answer."
print("\nFINAL:", run_agent("Why is our furniture business losing money and what should we
do?", Brain()))
```

OUTPUT

```
step 1 THINK: First find where we lose money.
        ACT: profit_by({'dim': 'sub_category'}) → 13 rows; first: {'sub_category':
'Tables', 'profit_m': -0.29, 'margin': -5.4}
step 2 THINK: Tables is the biggest loss-maker. Is it getting worse?
        ACT: trend({'sub_category': 'Tables'}) → 3 rows; first: {'yr': 2023.0,
'profit_m': -0.23}
step 3 THINK: Check whether discounts explain the Tables losses.
        ACT: discount_effect({'sub_category': 'Tables'}) → 3 rows; first: {'band':
'0%', 'n': 168, 'margin': 11.1}
step 4 THINK: I have enough evidence.

FINAL: Tables lost ₹0.29M in 2025. Margin is 11.1% without discount but -22.3% when
discounts exceed 20%. Recommendation: cap Tables discounts at 20% and review pricing.
```

With an LLM, `next_action` becomes a model call whose prompt contains the goal, the tool descriptions and the scratchpad; the model returns either a tool call or a final answer (the tool-use loop of lesson 6). This **reason + act** cycle is called **ReAct**.

Planning, reflection and memory

Pattern	Idea	Example
Plan-then-execute	Write a step list first, then run it, re-planning if needed	"1. Query losses 2. Check trend 3. Check discounts 4. Recommend"
Reflection / self-critique	Review the draft against criteria and revise	"Does every number come from a tool result?"
Evaluator–optimiser	One model generates, another grades and gives feedback until it passes	Report must cite figures and stay under 200 words
Short-term memory	The conversation and scratchpad in the context window	Observations so far
Long-term memory	Facts saved to a store and retrieved later	"This client prefers figures in lakh"
Context management	Summarise or clear old tool results in long runs	Compaction, context editing

Python

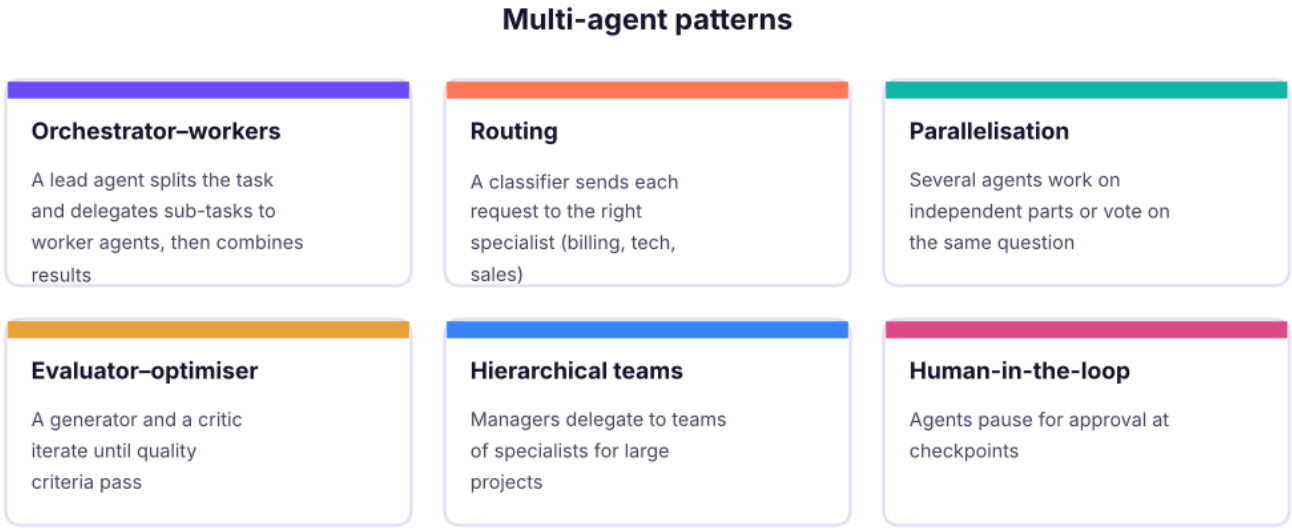
```python
def reflect(answer, scratch_numbers):
    issues = []
    nums = set(re.findall(r"-?\d+\.\d+|\d+", answer))
    unsupported = [n for n in nums if n not in scratch_numbers and n not in {"20", "2025"}]
    if unsupported: issues.append(f"numbers not found in tool results: {unsupported}")
    if len(answer.split()) > 80: issues.append("too long")
    if "recommend" not in answer.lower(): issues.append("no recommendation")
    return issues or ["passes checks"]
draft = "Tables lost ₹0.29M in 2025 and margins fell 12.5 points; recommend capping
discounts."
known = {"0.29", "2025", "-5.4", "-20.6"}
print(reflect(draft, known))
```

OUTPUT

```
["numbers not found in tool results: ['12.5']"]
```

A simple automated critic catches an invented number (12.5) before the answer reaches a manager: **verification beats trust**.

Multi-agent systems



Common multi-agent patterns.

Multi-agent systems help when work splits into **independent, context-heavy sub-tasks** (research across many sources, many files). They multiply token usage, so use them when the extra quality is worth it.

Agent platforms in 2026

Platform	What it gives you
Claude Agent SDK (Python/TypeScript)	The Claude Code agent harness as a library: file, shell, web and MCP tools, subagents, permissions
Claude Managed Agents	Anthropic-hosted agent loop and sandbox, sessions, scheduled runs
Anthropic API tool runner	Lightweight loop over your own tools (lesson 6)
OpenAI Agents SDK	Agents, handoffs, guardrails, tracing
LangGraph (LangChain)	Graph-based stateful workflows and agents with checkpoints
CrewAI, AutoGen / AG2, LlamaIndex agents	Multi-agent orchestration frameworks
No-code: n8n, Zapier agents, Microsoft Copilot Studio	Business automations with LLM steps

Pick by: how much control you need, where it must run (your cloud vs hosted), language, observability and team skills. Many production "agents" are really well-designed workflows with one or two agentic steps.

Guardrails and evaluation for agents

Risk	Control
Runaway loops and cost	Step limits, token/time budgets, stop conditions
Wrong or harmful actions	Least-privilege tools, approval for side effects, sandboxes, dry-run modes
Prompt injection from tools/web	Treat observations as data, restrict tools after reading untrusted content
Hallucinated facts	Require tool-sourced numbers, automated checks, citations
Silent failure	Tracing every step (LangSmith, Langfuse, OpenTelemetry), alerts
Quality drift	Task-level evaluation suites run on every change (lesson 9)

Should this be an agent? A checklist

1. **Complexity:** is the path hard to specify in advance?

2. **Value:** does the outcome justify extra cost and latency?
3. **Viability:** can current models do each step reliably (test it)?
4. **Cost of error:** can mistakes be caught and undone?

If any answer is "no", build a workflow or a single call instead.

Summary

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Agentic AI pursues goals through multi-step tool use; the model chooses the next action in a loop.
- Prefer single calls and workflows; use agents for open-ended, valuable tasks where errors can be caught.
- The agent loop: think, act (tool), observe, repeat, with step limits and clear stopping conditions (ReAct).
- Planning, reflection/evaluator patterns and memory improve agents; verify outputs against tool results.
- Multi-agent patterns (orchestrator–workers, routing, evaluator–optimiser) add power and cost.
- Guard agents with least privilege, approvals, budgets, tracing and evaluation.

Quick quiz

6 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. What distinguishes an agent from a workflow?

A In an agent the model decides the sequence of actions at run time

B Agents never use tools

C Workflows use LLMs, agents do not

D There is no difference

Answer: A. Workflows follow paths fixed in code.

2. What does ReAct stand for in agent design?

A Reasoning and acting: interleaving thoughts with tool actions and observations

B React.js front-end

C Reactive programming

D Retrieval-augmented action

Answer: A. Think → act → observe.

3. Which control prevents an agent from looping forever?

A A maximum number of steps or a token/time budget

B Higher temperature

C More tools

D Longer prompts

Answer: A. Always set stopping conditions.

4. When is a multi-agent design most useful?

A When work splits into independent, context-heavy sub-tasks

B For simple classification

C When cost must be minimal

D Always

Answer: A. It multiplies token use.

5. **An agent's report contains a number not found in any tool result. What pattern catches this?**

- **A** Reflection / an evaluator that checks claims against tool outputs
- **B** Higher temperature
- **C** Removing tools
- **D** Using a bigger context

Answer: A. Verify before delivering.

6. **Which is NOT a reason to choose an agent?**

- **A** The task is open-ended and multi-step
- **B** The outcome is valuable
- **C** A simple fixed sequence of steps solves it reliably
- **D** Errors can be detected and rolled back

Answer: C. Use a workflow then.

EXERCISE

Practice

(1) Extend the agent with a `region_breakdown(sub_category)` tool and a step that uses it. (2) Add a reflection step that rejects the final answer if it is over 60 words, and loop back. (3) Draw the architecture of a "monthly business review" agent: tools, data sources, approvals and outputs. (4) Decide workflow or agent for: invoice extraction, competitor research report, password reset.

Show solution (worked answer)

Python

```
TOOLS["region_breakdown"] = lambda sub_category: sql(f"SELECT region,
ROUND(SUM(profit)/1e6, 2) AS profit_m FROM sales WHERE sub_category = '{sub_category}'
AND YEAR(order_date) = 2025 GROUP BY 1 ORDER BY 2")
# (4) invoice extraction → single call / workflow with validation; competitor research
→ agent (open-ended, many sources, human review); password reset → deterministic
workflow, no LLM autonomy.
```

INTERVIEW CORNER

Questions you may be asked

Q: What is agentic AI and how is it different from generative AI? Generative AI produces content in response to a prompt; agentic AI uses models in a loop with tools and memory to pursue a goal across multiple steps, deciding what to do next.

Q: How would you design a reliable agent for business reporting? Narrow tools with read-only data access, a planning step, required tool-sourced numbers, an automated checker, human approval before distribution, step and cost limits, tracing, and an evaluation suite of past questions.

Q: When would you not use an agent? When a fixed workflow or single call solves the task, when errors are costly and hard to detect, or when latency and cost budgets are tight.

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